BEYOND MEDICAL SCHOOL

POSTGRADUATE STUDIES IN THE UK

A practical step-by-step guide

From preparing your documents to university admission

EXPOSURE • MENTORSHIP • OPPORTUNITY

Your UK postgraduate journey

A clear plan helps you move from an idea to a well-prepared application.

01 PLAN

Choose a programme that fits your interests, qualifications, career goals and budget.

02 PREPARE

Build a strong CV, personal statement and supporting-document package.

03 APPLY

Track deadlines, submit through official university portals and monitor your application.

04 CONFIRM

Review your offer, plan funding, meet conditions and prepare for travel.

This guide focuses on academic postgraduate study. Clinical specialty training is a separate pathway.

Step 1 — Define your goal

Start with the outcome you want, then work backwards to the right qualification.

Taught programmes

Structured teaching, modules and assessments.

Examples:

- MSc — Master of Science
- MPH — Master of Public Health

Research programmes

Designed around research training or an independent project.

Examples:

- MRes — Master of Research
- MPhil — Master of Philosophy
- PhD — Doctor of Philosophy

Fields to explore

Medical graduates may consider:

- Public health & epidemiology
- Clinical research & global health
- Biomedical sciences
- Healthcare management

Important: An academic degree such as an MSc or MPH does not, by itself, qualify a doctor for independent clinical practice in the UK.

Step 2 — Compare universities and courses

Use official university pages to confirm details before applying.

Course fit

Modules, research interests and teaching style

Eligibility

Academic qualifications and entry requirements

Cost

Tuition, living costs, deposits and scholarships

Timing

Intake dates, deadlines and course duration

Support

Research facilities, supervision and student services

Outcomes

Skills, networks and career relevance

Useful starting points **FindAMasters • FindAPhD • UCAS • Individual university websites**

Treat university websites as the primary source for current fees, requirements and application instructions.

Note: Some Universities offer certain Masters programmes tailored towards specific specialities so applicants must take that into consideration when applying for universities if they have such interests

Step 3 — Build a professional academic CV

Make it easy for an admissions team to see your preparation and suitability.

1. **Contact details**
   Professional email, phone with country code, location
2. **Profile**
   Brief summary of interests and career direction
3. **Education**
   Qualifications, institutions, dates and achievements
4. **Experience**
   Clinical work, housemanship, internships or employment
5. **Research**
   Projects, dissertations, publications and presentations
6. **Training & skills**
   Relevant courses, certifications, technical skills
7. **Leadership & awards**
   Relevant responsibilities and accomplishments
8. **Referees**
   Include name and contact details if requested by the programme

Tailor your CV to the course, use consistent dates, proofread carefully and follow the requested file format.

Step 4 — Write a compelling personal statement

Explain the connection between your background, this programme and your future plans.

1

Motivation

Why this course matters to you

2

Preparation

Relevant academic background and experience

3

Programme fit

Specific modules, faculty or research opportunities

4

Future goals

How the qualification supports your plans

5

Contribution

Strengths and perspectives you bring

Avoid

Generic statements, copied wording, unsupported claims and ignoring the word limit.

BMS tip

Draft once, then tailor the statement to each programme and its requirements.

Steps 5–7 — Complete your supporting documents

Start early: transcripts, references and test results can take time to arrange.

References

Potential referees:
- Lecturer or academic supervisor
- Research/dissertation supervisor
- Senior clinician or employer

Choose someone who knows your work and can give specific examples.

Certificates & transcripts

Prepare as requested:
- Degree certificate
- Official transcript
- Other relevant qualifications
- Professional registration, if required
- Awards or research abstract, if requested

English proficiency

Possible tests include:
- IELTS Academic
- TOEFL iBT
- Pearson PTE Academic

Confirm accepted tests, scores, component minimums and exemptions with the university.

Always follow the specific programme's instructions for referee type, document format and submission method.

Step 8 — Prepare a research proposal, if required

Research-based degrees may ask you to describe the question you want to investigate.

01 Title — A concise description of the proposed study

02 Rationale — Background, research problem and brief literature review

03 Question & aims — Research question, aim and specific objectives

04 Methods — Design, participants/data, analysis and feasibility

05 Ethics & impact — Ethical considerations and expected contribution

06 References — Relevant sources supporting the proposal

For a PhD, review the department's guidance and consider whether a potential supervisor's research aligns with your interests.

Step 9 — Explore funding early

Scholarship deadlines may be earlier than the course application deadline.

University awards
Merit-based or programme-specific scholarships

Government schemes
Eligible national or international scholarship programmes

Commonwealth awards
Check current eligibility and eligible courses

Research studentships
Often linked to a project or research department

Employer sponsorship
Confirm any service or employment conditions

Other institutions
Charities, foundations or professional bodies

For every award, check **Eligibility • Deadline • Tuition coverage • Living allowance • Travel support • Separate application?**

An admission offer does not guarantee funding; some awards cover only part of the total cost.

Step 10 — Submit a complete application

Most postgraduate applications are submitted through the university's official portal.

Create account

Use the official university portal

Select course

Confirm course, intake and study mode

Complete form

Enter accurate personal and academic details

Upload documents

CV, statement, certificates and transcripts

Arrange references

Follow the university's submission process

Review & submit

Check for errors; pay a fee if applicable

After submission: save confirmation, monitor your portal and email, and respond promptly to requests.

Steps 11–12 — Interview and offer

Not every course requires an interview; prepare if your programme does.

Prepare to discuss

- Why this course and university?
- How does your background prepare you?
- What do you hope to gain?
- What are your career goals?
- For research degrees: your question, methods and fit with the department.

Understand your offer

CONDITIONAL

You must satisfy specified requirements, such as final results, documents or English scores.

UNCONDITIONAL

Stated academic conditions have generally been met, but enrolment and immigration requirements may remain.

Before accepting: check deadlines, outstanding conditions, deposits, refund terms, start date and funding status.

Step 13 — Build a realistic budget

Estimate the full cost before committing to a course or travel plans.

Tuition

Fees and payment schedule

Accommodation

Rent, deposits and utilities

Living costs

Food, transport and essentials

Immigration

Visa fee and health surcharge, where applicable

Travel

Flights and local arrival costs

Study & reserve

Materials, insurance if relevant and emergency funds

Plan for the whole programme—not only the first payment.

Do not rely on part-time work as your only source of funding.

Steps 14–15 — CAS and Student visa

Use current official UK government guidance; requirements can change.

14 Confirmation of Acceptance for Studies

For eligible courses, an approved Student sponsor may issue a CAS after you meet its requirements.

A CAS is a unique reference used in a Student visa application—it is not a visa.

Check that your personal and course details are correct.

15 Student visa documents

Depending on your circumstances, you may need:

- Valid passport and CAS reference
- Evidence of sufficient funds
- English proficiency, if required
- ATAS certificate, if applicable
- Tuberculosis test results, if required
- Other documents specified by the rules

Official guidance: gov.uk/student-visa • gov.uk/student-visa/course

Check the latest rules and refund policies before making substantial non-refundable payments.

Step 16 — Prepare for travel and arrival

Make your first weeks easier by organising essentials before departure.

1

Housing

Compare university and reputable private accommodation; read contracts carefully.

2

Travel

Plan flights around the permitted arrival period and your course start date.

3

Documents

Keep copies of passport, offer, CAS and key records accessible.

4

Arrival

Confirm transport, check-in and university arrival arrangements.

5

Enrolment

Review registration steps, orientation and any outstanding tasks.

6

Safety

Avoid sending deposits to unverified people or organisations.

Keep digital and printed copies of important documents, and store them securely.

Before you press submit

Use this final review to catch missing documents and missed deadlines.

PLAN

- ☐ Goal and course selected
- ☐ Entry requirements checked
- ☐ Deadlines and fees recorded

DOCUMENTS

- ☐ CV tailored
- ☐ Statement tailored
- ☐ References requested
- ☐ Transcripts/certificates ready
- ☐ English requirements checked

APPLY & FUND

- ☐ Funding researched
- ☐ Form reviewed
- ☐ Documents uploaded
- ☐ Confirmation saved

AFTER OFFER

- ☐ Conditions reviewed
- ☐ Budget confirmed
- ☐ CAS/visa requirements checked
- ☐ Housing and travel planned

Keep an application tracker with programme names, portal links, deadlines, referee status and decisions.

YOUR NEXT STEP

Choose your programme.
Check the requirements.
Start your documents.

A strong application starts with a clear goal and careful preparation.

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Exposure • Mentorship • Opportunity